



The Great Search Engine War

Is Google's dominance under threat?

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When you think search, you think Google! Though Google has undoubtedly ruled the roost thus far, they may have to fight for dominance soon—if Yahoo! and MSN have their way, that is. Both Yahoo! and MSN are taking this war seriously.

US-based market researcher WebSideStory recently rated Google as the best search engine, ahead of its rivals. According to the survey, as of March 23, 2004, Google accounted for 41 per cent of all Web referrals—up from 36 per cent in March 2003. Yahoo, launched in 1994, and the Web's oldest directory, came in second at 27 per cent, down four per cent from a year ago. MSN was placed third at just under 20 per cent.

WebSideStory claims to have sampled 25 million unique browsers on March 23, and that the one-day results are indicative of search activity for the entire month.

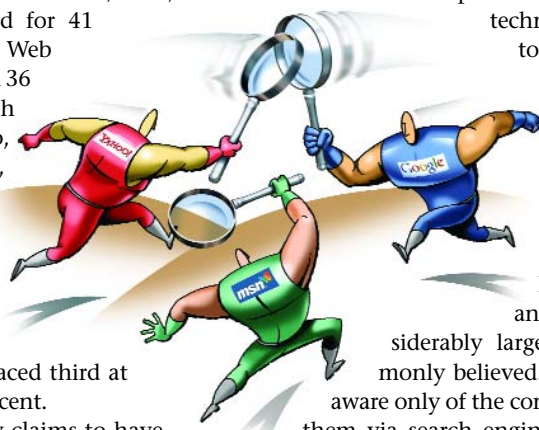
Earlier this year, Nielsen/NetRatings reported that in January, 39 per cent of active Internet surfers—that's about 59.3 million unique viewers—used Google search, while Yahoo and MSN attracted approximately 30 per cent each.

SearchEngineWatch.com rates Google as numero uno, based on reader reviews. Google's additional features such as cached links, spell checks, access to dictionary definitions, stock quotes, maps, telephone numbers, etc., have made it popular among netizens. Yahoo! ranks second again.

In October 2002, Yahoo! shifted to crawler-based listings for its main results—these came from Google until February 2004. Like Google, Yahoo sells paid placement advertising links through Overture, a company it purchased in October 2003. Overture, combined with Inktomi—another Yahoo! subsidiary—developed the current Yahoo crawler.

Yahoo! recently unveiled the Yahoo! search platform—YST. Yahoo! representatives claim that use of their search engine had increased dramatically due to the new technology. And Yahoo! has also tied up with Macromedia to use Flash content in its search results.

Keep an eye on MSN Search as well. Previously powered by LookSmart, MSN had its own team of editors that monitored the most popular searches being performed to hand-pick the most relevant sites. Today MSN has developed its own crawler-based technology, and plans to enter the search engine market in a big way.



The Surface and the Deep

The Internet is a lot more diverse, and its volume considerably larger, than is commonly believed. Most people are aware only of the content presented to them via search engines, or directories such as **About.com**. The largest growing category of new information on the Internet, the 'deep Web', is a massive collection of databases, schedules and research data—about 90 terabytes of data that don't find their way onto a typical search results page.

Yahoo! recently introduced its Content Acquisition Program, to index the billions of documents on the deep Web. It's collaborating with the Library of Congress, the University of California at Los Angeles, the University of Michigan, and Project Gutenberg, amongst others, to begin populating its index with fresh, searchable, thus far, unavailable material.

Google isn't resting on its laurels, either. They're said to be working on a project called 'Puffin', which will bring Google's search technologies to your desktop. This move will put it at loggerheads with Microsoft, rivalling the Windows file system search—ensuring Google.com remains your default search engine, and not MSN.com that Microsoft would connect to. Wait and watch as the search superpowers battle it out for world domination.



WAITING IN THE WINGS

64-Bit Computing

AMD fired off the first salvo by getting the Athlon FX—the first desktop PC 64-bit processor.

Intel doesn't seem to be following suit, but Microsoft has announced that they will be launching a 64-bit version of Windows XP.

Early days yet, but gamers can rejoice—upcoming games will have support for 64-bit processors. Apple's G5 is a 64-bit processor, and MacOS 10.3 supports 64-bit computing. PC software will move to 64-bit as well, over the next couple of years. It's a step into the future.